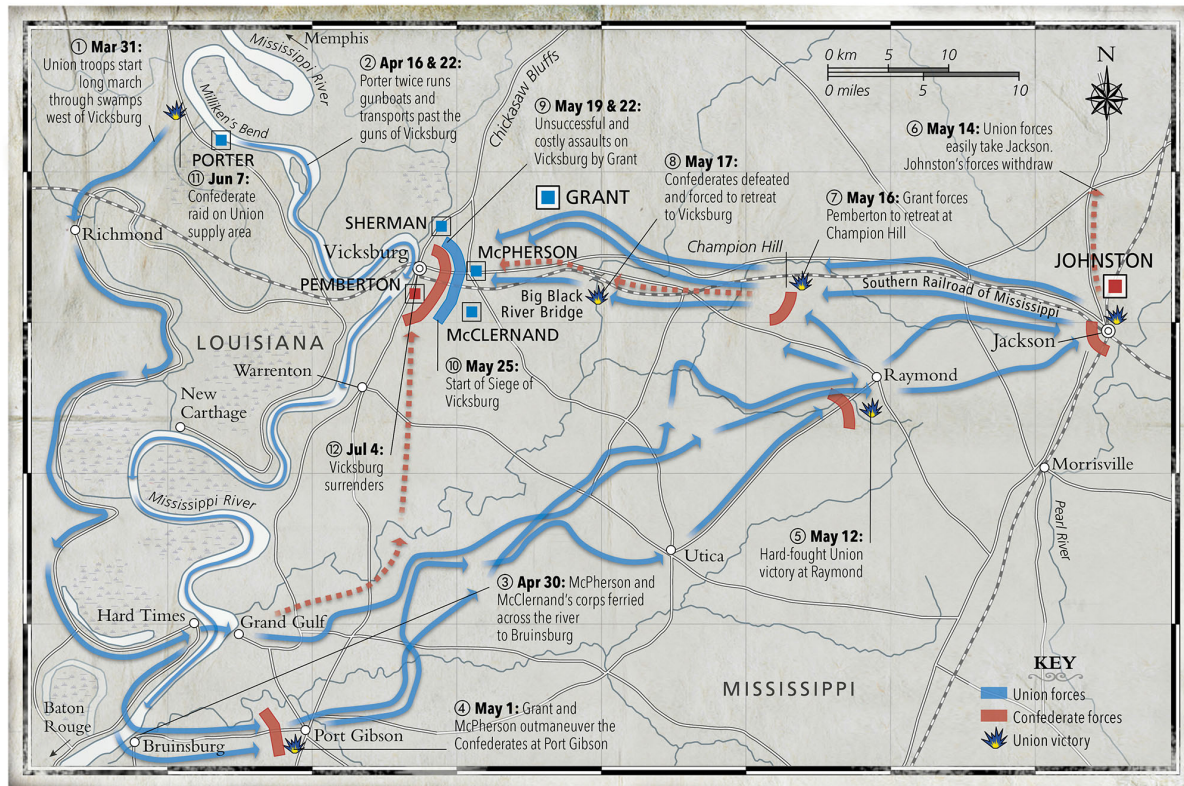




Grant's routes to Vicksburg

The Vicksburg campaign was not straightforward. Grant had to march his men through the swampland west of the Mississippi River, then drive off Confederate forces east of the city before digging in for a long siege.

Union victories

The War Department in Richmond finally ordered Johnston to concentrate his growing command at Jackson, but Sherman's and McPherson's fast-moving corps beat him to the city. Defeating about 6,000 graycoats entrenched outside the city on May 14, the Union soldiers went to work burning railroad yards, factories, and arsenals. Civilian homes close to the fires also went up in flames. Looking on Jackson's smoking ruins, Union soldiers derisively dubbed them "Chimneyville." This destruction of the enemy's infrastructure and civilian property set a precedent for future Union operations in the Western Theater.

Undeterred, Johnston urged Pemberton to move quickly to join his own remaining 6,000 men. On May 16, Grant struck hard at Pemberton's advance force at Champion Hill, between Jackson and